

Vietnam



French rule of Vietnam ended in 1954. Divided at 17°N, the US-backed South fought the Communist North. Reunified after the North's 1975 victory, it is run as a single-party state.



GEOGRAPHY

A heavily forested mountain range separates the northern Red River delta lowlands from the Mekong Delta in the south.



CLIMATE

Cool winters in north; south is tropical, with even temperatures.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic Vietnamese dominate; the Chinese minority was viewed as a corrupt bourgeoisie by the victorious Communists after the war. Mountain-based minorities (*montagnards*) were also sidelined; tensions persist over the settling of highlands by lowlanders. Women play an active role in society. There is no political or press freedom.



INSIGHT: Intense US bombing and defoliant spraying in the 1962–1975 Vietnam War has scarred the landscape



THE ECONOMY

Liberal economic policy (*doi moi*) from 1986: now one of fastest-growing economies. Major rice exporter. Cheap labor. Strong manufacturing: textiles, electrical goods. Diverse resource base.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Socialist Republic of Vietnam

DATE OF FORMATION: 1976

CAPITAL: Hanoi

POPULATION: 88.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 127,243 sq. miles
(329,560 sq. km)

DENSITY: 701 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Vietnamese*, Chinese, other

RELIGIONS: Nonreligious 81%, Buddhist 9%, Christian 7%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Vietnamese 86%, other 10%, Tay 2%, Thai 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Đồng = 10 hao = 100 xu